RISE

Command Philosophy

College of Professional Military Education

On being appointed to command the College of Professional Military Education, I am following the tradition of setting out a command philosophy. I begin with what I have learned, while recognising that serving with you will give me reasons to think again. My past experience informs how I approach command; it need not settle how I should act in every new circumstance. In particular, when I served as Acting Commanding Officer of the Combat Support Battalion in 2022–2023, I wrote and said that command, as I then understood it, required me to RISE: Represent, Inspire, Shape and Empower. Those words helped me explain how I intended to serve. Since then, I have continued to examine what each requires of me and how they belong together. I now express that connection in one phrase: "*Represent through Inspiration while Shaping to Empower.*" Let me explain why I have joined the words this way.

Command takes place through our dealings with one another, moment by moment, and through the relationships those dealings establish over time. What I do affects your opportunities to act, while what you do and choose to tell me can change how I understand my responsibilities. For example, how I respond when you report a difficulty may affect whether you feel able to raise another concern. Likewise, whether I provide the resources for a task may affect what you can accomplish, while the reasons you give for approaching it differently may help me improve my own judgement. These relationships therefore involve influence in both directions, although my appointment gives me particular authority and makes me answerable for how I exercise it. Nor need everything we learn from one another end when an appointment or course ends: people may carry that learning into later work, family life and service to their communities. That possibility gives our daily conduct a significance beyond the immediate task, while leaving each person's wider life their own. With that relationship in view, let us consider what each part of RISE requires.

Represent means that I will speak fairly about the people entrusted to my command and, where my role calls for it, speak on their behalf. To do that, I first need to listen to what you choose to tell me and check that I have understood it. Listening does not require you to disclose every part of your life; it requires me to attend carefully to what you share and recognise the boundaries of what I know. If our accounts differ, I should examine that difference before claiming that mine speaks for us both. Representing also requires me to demonstrate the standards I expect, including acknowledging when my own conduct falls short. So I repeat: *representing includes listening*, because I cannot fairly speak for you merely by assuming that I understand you.

Through Inspiration, in turn, describes how I seek to make my example encouraging and useful. I can show how a task might be approached, explain why it matters and help you see a possibility you have not yet considered. However, encouragement acquires substance through what I help place within your reach. If I invite you to undertake demanding work, I should arrange suitable teaching, resources, time to practise and opportunities to begin. Where I cannot provide something, I should explain the constraint and consider what can be changed. Otherwise, I risk encouraging you towards an expectation that our arrangements do little to support. Hence, I repeat: *inspiring requires provision*. My example may help you begin, while your subsequent learning may give you grounds to improve upon it.

While Shaping then directs attention to the continuing work of examining and improving the tasks, guidance and conditions within my remit. Those arrangements affect how you work and learn, so I should explain the professional requirements they serve and hear suggestions for meeting them better. For instance, if several learners struggle with the same instruction, I should examine how we explained it alongside how they responded. If a task repeatedly requires people to work without adequate resources, I should examine what we provide before treating their difficulty as a personal failing. Granted, professional duties place real demands upon us; those demands make clear purposes, suitable preparation and fair assessment more necessary. Here, though, we should distinguish shaping the conditions for professional development from determining the whole person someone should become. I can prepare you for responsibilities and assess whether you have demonstrated the capabilities they require. Your ambitions and future nevertheless extend beyond what I can foresee or properly direct. Therefore, I repeat: *shaping respects each person's own future*, including the possibility that they will meet a professional requirement in a better way than the one I first knew.

To Empower identifies the purpose towards which I direct this work: helping people, where they need my support and I can properly provide it, to develop the capabilities and obtain the means to act responsibly. Within the College, those means include information, resources, support and clearly defined authority appropriate to the task. By authority, here, I mean knowing which decisions you are entrusted to make, which require referral and where you can obtain assistance. Simply assigning responsibility cannot supply those means. Moreover, what people learn here may help them act more thoughtfully in their own lives and communities, although the College cannot grant authority over those settings or prescribe how each person should live. Empowering also requires me to hear your questions and examine your reasons, especially when they challenge my own judgement. You, in turn, can help that examination by identifying the matter at issue, explaining your reasons and considering what evidence might change your view. Where your judgement is better supported, I should recognise it and revise mine. In that sense, you can also empower me: what you know, notice and explain may enable me to act more responsibly than I could have acted alone. So I repeat: *empowering makes room for warranted disagreement*. Disagreeing with me does not, by itself, establish misconduct, just as agreeing with me does not, by itself, establish sound judgement.

Now return to the connecting words. "Through" identifies a way of representing: I seek to make my example something others can learn from. "While" connects that example to the daily work of improving the conditions in which we serve. "To" states the main purpose: helping people become better able to understand, judge and act responsibly. Empowerment is therefore the main purpose by which I ask us to examine these actions as we fulfil the College's professional duties. We can ask whether people understand what is required, can obtain the means to undertake it, can explain their choices and can raise a concern that receives fair consideration. We can also ask what changes after they speak, because an invitation to contribute becomes credible partly through what follows. This is how I presently understand RISE, and I offer it as an undertaking you can examine through my conduct. I hope I have made the reasoning clear. I welcome your ideas, questions and feedback, including where my words need clarifying or my practice needs to change.

Othneil S V Blackwood

RISE in Brief

Give Anonymous Feedback

The water lilies honour my mother, Jean, who rose from hardship at society's margins to greatness of character before her passing in 2022.